



one people, providing a live real indicator of how things can change between India and Pakistan.

Still, it will take awesome political courage for any Indian leader to shift course on policy towards the Pakistani people. Both Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and Congress leader Sonia Gandhi have displayed such courage recently. Now the Indian people have to show similar courage by supporting them strongly. And when the Pakistani millstone is finally taken off India's neck, our country will walk with a real spring in its step.

Equally importantly, a new great game of geo-politics is emerging. Goldman Sachs is right in predicting that the three largest economies in the world in 2050 will be China, India and America (and in that order). Hence,

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the relations between the three will determine the geo-political dynamics of the world.

There is a very simple almost mathematical equation that will determine which of the three powers will have a strategic advantage in this great game: the one power that has better relations with the other two will have a natural leverage. Right now America has better relations with China and India than China and India have with each other. By leaning in favour of one or another, America can gain strategic leverage.

Both China and India can also gain similar strategic leverage by significantly improving relations with each other. In some ways, relations have never been better. Over the past decade, China and India have set goals of achieving \$10 billion, then \$20 billion, and then \$30 billion bilateral trade by 2010. Yet by 2008, trade has exceeded \$50 billion. In many global challenges, from climate change to the

Doha Round, from jihadi terrorism to Third World solidarity, China and India have common interests and positions.

Yet, despite all this, suspicions are rising on bilateral issues: from border disputes to nuclear proliferation, from Myanmar to maritime expansion. And, of course, China's relations with Pakistan have been a constant challenge. Hence, here too the removal of the Pakistan millstone will liberate Sino-Indian relations and enable both to focus on the larger geo-political gains that come from global cooperation rather than bilateral zero-sum games.

There is one fundamental common interest both China and India share. From the year 1 to 1820, they provided the world's two largest economies. It took a massive amount of under-performance for both to fall badly behind the West and to be brutally exploited. Only a hundred years ago, 300 million Indians were ruled by just 100,000 Englishmen. And China too suffered from humiliating Western territorial settlements.

Now both China and India have an extraordinary opportunity to shake off two hundred years of incompetent performance to become the world's two greatest powers. Both can help to lift each other up. Or both can pull each

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other down. The strategic choice is clear.

It is also clear that all of Asia wants China and India to succeed. As the former Singapore prime minister, Goh Chok Tong, once said, India and China can provide two powerful jet engines to lift their societies and the rest of Asia as we soar into the 21st century. Indeed, there has never been a better historical opportunity for all of Asia than the moment we are experiencing now.

This is why the moment has come for the Indian establishment to engage in deep reflection on India's future in the next 100 years. Such moments of historical opportunity as we are experiencing now never come easily. A favourable correlation of forces has opened a new window of opportunity for India. And if India can engage in new and bold strategic thinking and slay several sacred cows along the way, the Indian dream may finally be realised.

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Poised at a historic cusp, India could in the next two decades either attain great power status or become a giant non-entity.”

ARUN PRAKASH
former chief of
the naval staff



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